

Although most grape vines are self-fertile, those grown under cover need help because they are not exposed to the wind—their usual method of pollination. Shake the vine gently to help it transfer its pollen. Move container-grown plants outside for a month in winter—the cold induces flowering.

CARE OF OUTDOOR VINES

Feed and mulch outdoor vines as for indoor-grown types, and water newly planted vines in dry spells; once established, they will not require further watering.

Thin foliage in late summer to allow sunlight to reach the fruits; trim back with sterile pruners, taking care not to touch the delicate fruits. Prune and train as for indoor vines (see tip box).

HARVESTING AND STORING

As fruits ripen, their skins become slightly translucent and develop a bloom. Sample the fruits to check whether they are fully ripe, and use scissors or pruners to cut a whole bunch free at a time. This helps to prevent damage to the fruits. Once picked, grapes will not keep fresh for more than a few days, so eat them or use them as soon as possible after harvesting.

PESTS AND DISEASES

Due to the higher temperatures, grapes grown in greenhouses are more at risk from pests and diseases than those grown outside, although outside vines may need to be netted to keep birds from stealing the fruits.

It is especially important to maintain good garden hygiene in the warm climate of the greenhouse: ensure that plants have sufficient space and ventilation, and ensure that plants are neither over- or underwatered. Also be aware that vines are easily damaged by chemical weedkillers, and that many are prone to magnesium deficiency.

Common diseases include: gray mold, and downy and powdery mildews. Common pests include mealy bugs and red spider mites. Be vigilant, and inspect for early signs of damage.



Vine leaf blister mites (left) create yellow-brown blisters on leaves. Powdery mildew (right) coats the fruits, causing them to split.